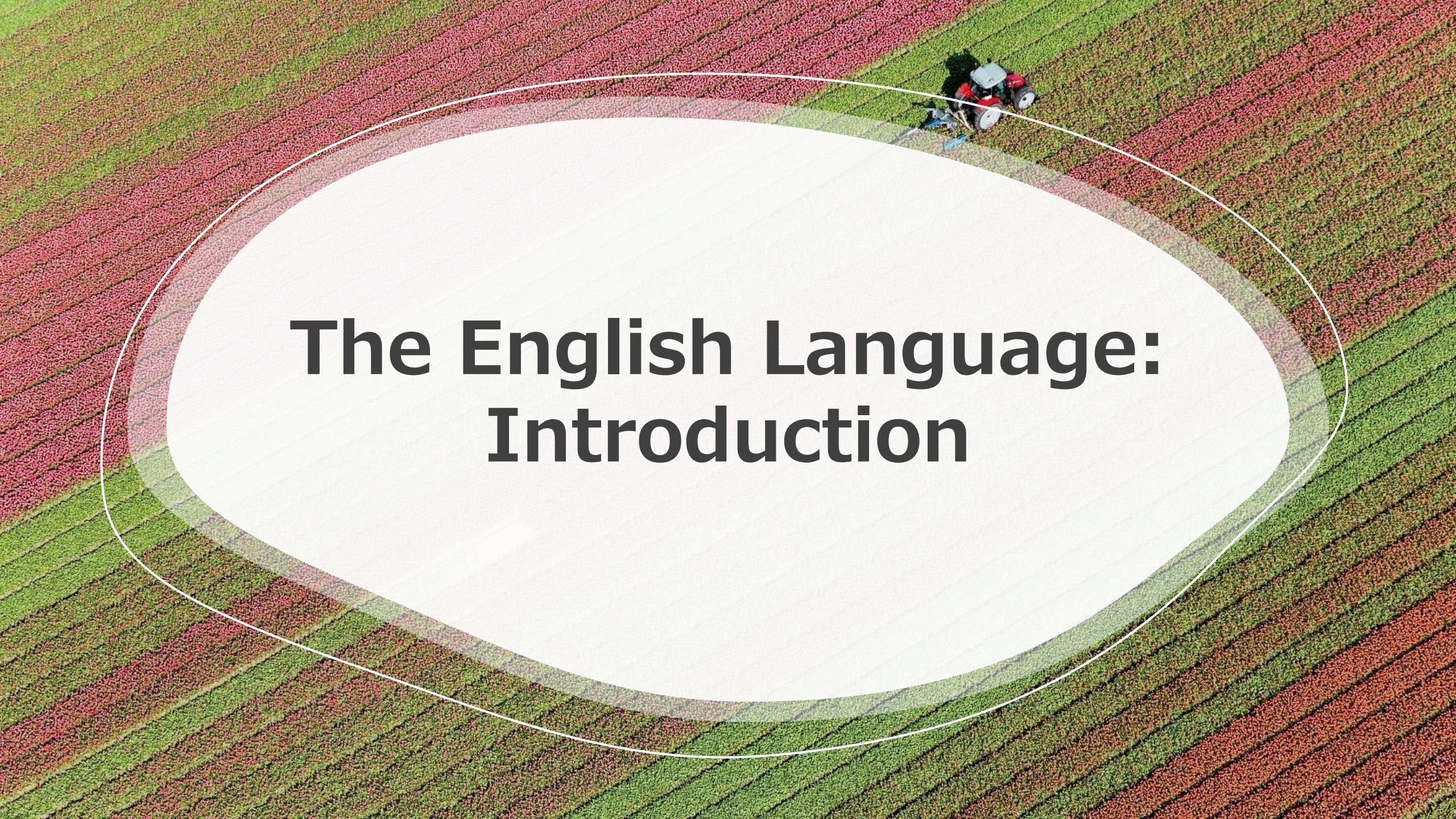


An aerial photograph of a vast field with alternating rows of red and green plants, likely a flower field. A small tractor is visible in the upper right corner. A large, white, rounded rectangular overlay is centered on the image, containing the title text.

The English Language: Introduction

The English Language

1.1 The English language

Introduction

English is the third most common native language in the world (after Mandarin Chinese and Spanish) but it has the most widespread use of any language.

- ❑ It is the first language of the majority populations of many countries (including the United Kingdom, the United States, Canada, Australia, Ireland, New Zealand, many Caribbean countries and a number of Pacific states);
- ❑ it is an official language of many commonwealth countries, the European Union and the United Nations; and
- ❑ it is widely learned as a second language (the numbers of people in Pakistan who speak English and people in China who are learning English are both greater than the population of the UK).

English in many cases is the required international language of communication, science, information technology, business, seafaring, and aviation.

Why is English so widespread?

Great Britain's colonial activities established English in many parts of the world, and the emergence of Great Britain as a global economic superpower in the nineteenth century, reinforced its importance.

The twentieth century saw the decline of British influence but the rise of American influence and this has accelerated the spread of the language across the planet resulting in English becoming the *lingua franca* of the modern era.



Definition: Lingua franca

A language used as a common language between speakers whose native languages are different.



Illustration

A large percentage of the adult population of non-English-speaking EU countries claim to be able to speak English, including 85% in Sweden, 83% in Denmark, and 79% in the Netherlands.

“British English” or “American English”?

English taken to different parts of the world has sometimes evolved in slightly different ways. For example, there are slight differences between spelling in the UK and spelling in the USA and, in some cases, different words are used. This text will always use British English spelling and English words. However, that is not to say that American spelling is wrong; it is just different in some cases.

The word processing software most commonly used in the world is Microsoft Word. The software includes a function to check spelling and grammar that is based on “American English”. This can be changed to “British English” if desired.

Either spellings can be used but should be used consistently. In other words documents should either always use American constructions or always use British constructions. They should not be mixed. Common differences will be listed in the vocabulary section of this book.

Spoken or written?

All languages begin in the spoken form. In the course of time, speakers of some languages develop a set of signs and symbols that can be used to represent the language in the written form.

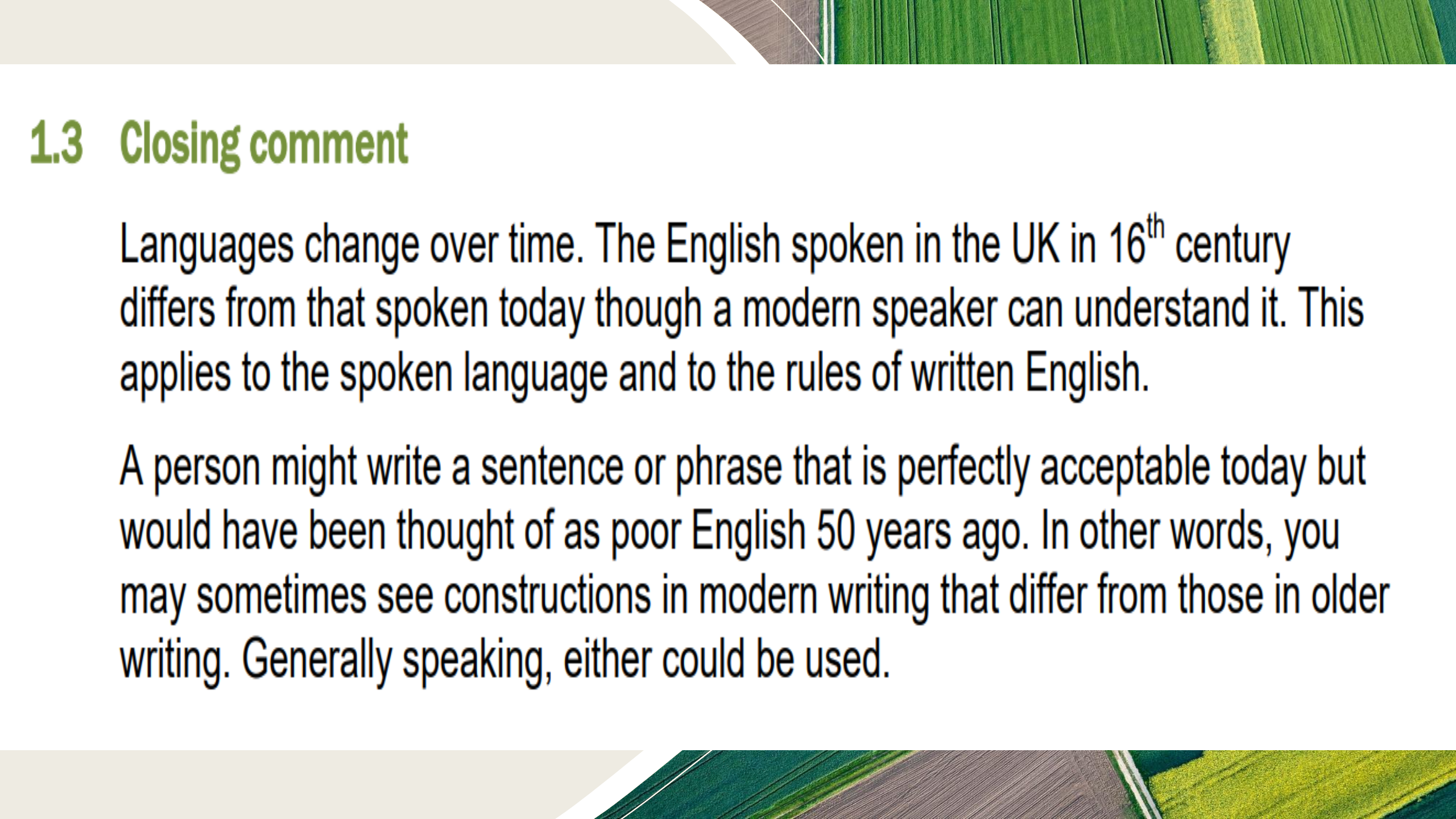
The rules of the English language apply whether it is spoken or written. However, the rules are applied less formally in spoken English. For example, phrases are often contracted in spoken English. Such contractions should not be used in written English (unless reporting speech). Common contractions will be shown later in this text as appropriate.



Example: Contraction

“I will” is often contracted to “I’ll” in spoken English.

English is a forgiving language. It can be twisted and misused in the spoken form but meaning can usually be understood from the context of a sentence. However, written English should always be in the proper form. A native English speaker is far less forgiving of mistakes in written English than he would be of mistakes in spoken English.

An aerial photograph of a rural landscape featuring a patchwork of green agricultural fields, some with distinct furrows. A narrow road or path runs through the fields. The image is partially visible at the top and bottom of the slide.

1.3 Closing comment

Languages change over time. The English spoken in the UK in 16th century differs from that spoken today though a modern speaker can understand it. This applies to the spoken language and to the rules of written English.

A person might write a sentence or phrase that is perfectly acceptable today but would have been thought of as poor English 50 years ago. In other words, you may sometimes see constructions in modern writing that differ from those in older writing. Generally speaking, either could be used.

Part of speech	Comment
Verb	Used to describe an action, state or occurrence. The term “verb phrase” is used to describe a verb with other words to indicate tense, mood or person.
Adverb	Used to modify the meaning of a verb, adjective or another adverb.
Noun	Used to identify any of a class of people, places or things (common noun) or to name a particular one of these (proper noun).
Pronoun	Used instead of a noun to indicate something or someone already mentioned (e.g. him, her, it).
Adjective	Used to provide extra information about a noun. Includes “determiners” – see below.
Preposition	Used with a noun to provide information about position or movement (e.g. on, at, over).
Conjunction	Used to join two words or clauses (e.g. and, but).
Interjection	Used as an exclamation (e.g. Oh! Stop!).

Some texts separate out the determiners from the other adjectives as a separate part of speech. A determiner is used to provide extra information about a noun. It is said to “mark” a noun.

Determiner	Examples
Articles	<i>the, a, an</i>
Possessive adjectives	<i>my, your, his, her, its, our, and their.</i>
Demonstrative adjectives	<i>this, that, these, and those</i>
Interrogative adjectives	<i>what, which, and whose</i>
Quantifiers	<i>many, few, half, etc.</i> Cardinal numbers – <i>one, two, three</i> etc. Ordinal numbers – <i>first, second, third</i> etc.

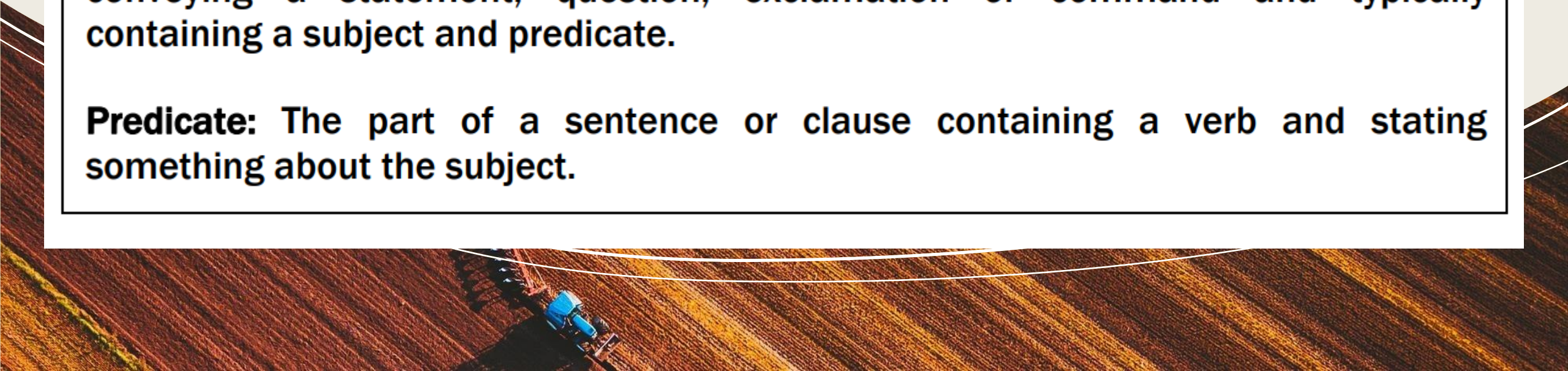
Sentences – an introduction

This section provides an introduction to the construction of sentences. Subsequent chapters will expand on the contents of this section.

Definitions

Sentence: A set of words that is complete in itself (expresses a complete idea), conveying a statement, question, exclamation or command and typically containing a subject and predicate.

Predicate: The part of a sentence or clause containing a verb and stating something about the subject.



Constructing sentences

There are some very easy basic rules in constructing sentences:

- ❑ they always begin with a capital letter;
- ❑ they always end with a full stop, question mark or exclamation mark; and
- ❑ a sentence can contain any number of words but longer sentences need more skill in their construction.

A predicate may or may not include an object.

Sentences perform one of a series of different functions. These are described as the mood of the sentence.

Functions of a sentence	Mood	Illustrations
To make a statement	Declarative	This is a declarative sentence.
To ask a question	Interrogative	Is this an interrogative sentence?
To make a command or issue an instruction	Imperative	Learn these terms.
To express surprise, shock or disbelief	Exclamatory	These terms are impossible!
To express a wish or desire	Optative	I wish these terms were easier to remember.

Parts of the sentence

Sentences consist of a series of standard components (***parts of the sentence***). Each ***part of the sentence*** is built from the ***parts of speech*** that were described previously. These standard components are as follows:

Part of sentence	Explanation
Subject	A noun, pronoun or noun phrase (a group of words that performs the function of a noun). The subject either indicates what the sentence is about or who or what is performing an action.
Verb	Verb phrase is a wider term than verb and this will be used in the rest of this text. This part of the sentence identifies an action or state of being. The verb phrase is also known as the predicate of the sentence.

Further explanation requires knowledge of a few more terms.

Definitions

Phrase: A group of words.

Clause: A group of words containing a verb, a subject and perhaps an object.

Subordinate clause: A clause that contains extra information about the main clause.

A main clause can stand alone as a sentence whereas a subordinate clause would not do so in the context of the sentence.

Types of sentence

Type of sentence	Explanation	Illustrations
Simple sentence	A sentence that consists of one clause.	I hit the ball.
Compound sentence	A sentence that consists of two main clauses joined together by a conjunction such as <i>and</i> , <i>but</i> , <i>or</i> .	Anwar hit the ball and it flew out of the ground.
Complex sentence	A sentence that consists of a main clause supported by a subordinate clause joined together by a conjunction such as <i>because</i> , <i>if</i> , <i>that</i> , <i>when</i> etc.	We will play cricket when Iqbal brings the ball.

The above illustration of a compound sentence could be written as two separate sentences:

- ❑ ***Anwar hit the ball.*** – A complete sentence
- ❑ ***It flew out of the ground.*** – A complete sentence

The above illustration of a complex sentence contains one clause which could form an independent sentence and one that could not.

- ❑ ***We will play cricket.*** – A complete sentence
- ❑ ***When Iqbal brings the ball.*** – This clause is an incomplete sentence in the context in which it is used. In other words, it is a subordinate clause. (Note that this same clause would be a complete sentence if it were answering the question *When will we play cricket?*)

A simple sentence is a sentence that consists of a single clause.

A clause, and therefore the sentence, may or may not have an object.

Example: Object and no object

Subject	Verb	Object
She	is reading	a book.
She	is reading.	

A verb with an object is called a transitive verb whereas one without an object is called an intransitive verb.

Many verbs may be either transitive or intransitive.

The order of words in sentences (syntax) is very important in English. Changing word order can change the whole meaning of a sentence.

Example: Word order

Subject

Verb

Object

The man

is chasing.

the dog

The dog

is chasing.

the man

Different moods are often achieved by changing the order of the parts of the sentence.

Example: Mood

	Subject	Verb
Declarative	I	am walking.
	Verb	Subject
Interrogative	Am	I walking?

The following examples are given to illustrate other parts of a sentence.

Example: Adverbial and complement

Complements: The meal was *delicious*

The man was *very tall*.

Adverbials: It snowed *heavily in the winter*

SELF-TEST

1

Identify the underlined parts of speech:

- (a) Where there is smoke, there is fire.
- (b) Noman travels to Dubai frequently.
- (c) It has been years since I saw you last.
- (d) The local train to Landhi always runs late on Sundays.
- (e) The birds' calls blend into a sweet song.
- (f) Have you heard anything new?
- (g) Please give me the pair of scissors.
- (h) Where have you placed the new cupboard?

(04)

2

Indicate the part of speech the word **fast** performs in each of the following sentences:

- (a) One of the aims of a fast is to think of poor people who do not have sufficient food to eat.
- (b) Imran is a fast runner.
- (c) Shoaib can run fast.
- (d) In Ramzan, Muslims are expected to fast from dawn to sunset.

(04)

**This is the end of first chapter.
Now I am waiting for your
interviews to be performed
in front of the whole class.**